

Checklist

Engineering Executive: Gelling Your Engineering Leadership Team

Debugging & Establishing the Team (First 60–90 Days)

Assess the Current Team

- ☐ Identify members who may need to move on (behavioral issues or active damage vs. simple underperformance).
- ☐ Identify broken relationship pairs (internal or with key stakeholders).
- ☐ Evaluate whether the org structure brings the right leaders into the room.
- ☐ Ensure key domains (e.g., Data, Security, Infrastructure) are properly represented.

Form Initial Hypotheses

- ☐ Develop a clear point of view for your leadership team.
- ☐ Actively try to disprove your early assumptions.
- ☐ Validate perceptions through 1:1s and observation.

Take Decisive Action

- ☐ Move out individuals who won't be part of the long-term team.
- ☐ Set clear expectations for those who remain.
- ☐ Make personnel decisions quickly to reset team dynamics.
- ☐ Consider starting with a broader team early on.

- ☐ Ensure that the technical perspective is represented (e.g., by senior engineers or architects).

Operating the Leadership Team

Define Team Values

- Clarify how decisions are made.
- Define how conflicts are navigated.
- Align on when to escalate vs. resolve directly.
- Align team values with broader company values.
- Document values (if helpful) and enforce them consistently.

Establish Team Structure

- Define recurring meetings and rituals.
- Clarify information flow from exec team to leadership team.
- Establish clear escalation pathways.
- Decide on update cadence (weekly reports, chat updates, etc.).

Create Space for Human Connection

- Build informal, unstructured interaction time.
- Avoid purely transactional relationships.
- Encourage relationship-building outside structured meetings.

Referee Defection from Values

- ☐ Address value violations immediately.
- ☐ Hold members accountable consistently.
- ☐ Avoid tolerating repeated behavioral drift.
- ☐ Reinforce that values apply to everyone.

Setting Expectations for Team Members

Leading Their Teams

- ☐ Clarify how leaders will be evaluated (execution vs. firefighting vs. vision).
- ☐ Align on performance expectations.
- ☐ Ensure they understand business-level goals.

Communicating with Peers

- ☐ Set expectations for cross-functional engagement.
- ☐ Avoid siloed, heads-down leadership behavior.
- ☐ Define how to handle peer conflicts.

Staying Aligned with Peers

- ☐ Clarify when to resolve vs. escalate.
- ☐ Define escalation norms (together vs. separately).
- ☐ Encourage shared ownership over competing priorities.

Building Their Own Leadership Teams

- ☐ Ensure each leader develops their own strong team.
- ☐ Reinforce “turtles all the way down” leadership consistency.
- ☐ Encourage cascading communication of priorities and values.

Navigating You (the Executive)

- ☐ Clarify your working style (risk tolerance, process preference).
- ☐ Share decision-making philosophy.
- ☐ Make stakeholder prioritization explicit.
- ☐ Consider creating a personal README.

Preventing Competition Among Peers

- ☐ Watch for collaboration drifting into internal competition.
- ☐ Address perceived lack of opportunity.
- ☐ Encourage non-zero-sum growth opportunities.
- ☐ Reinforce that future capacity > current capacity.
- ☐ Avoid tolerating value violations that fuel competition.

Ongoing Maintenance

- ☐ Revisit expectations regularly.
- ☐ Periodically re-evaluate team composition.
- ☐ Reinforce values in weekly meetings.
- ☐ Address small tensions before they grow.
- ☐ Invest consistently in relationships.